



## LANCASTER COUNTY, PENNSYLVANIA USA

# Dutch Pie in Lancaster County

A visit to Pennsylvania's Lancaster County is a step back in time. Bearded men in wide-brimmed black hats drive horse-drawn buggies through the streets, while women in plain 19th-century dresses and bonnets sell quilts and jellies in the farmers' markets. And drifting from the bakeries and kitchen windowsills is the sweet, heavenly smell of home-baked Pennsylvania Dutch pie.



The quaint towns and neat family farms of Pennsylvania Dutch country are a world away from the urban buzz of Philadelphia. Head off the beaten tourist track

onto the quiet rural roads here and you'll enter a landscape of rolling green hills and woodlands, dotted with large whitewashed farmhouses, covered "kissing bridges," windmills, and sturdy old barns built to last a century or two. In winter the farmers plow the fields using horses, not tractors, and in summer they bale hay with pitchforks onto wooden wagons.

The term Pennsylvania "Dutch" is a corruption of the word "Deutsch," the name for the German-speaking settlers who came here in the early 1700s. It includes the Amish communities, who live a simple life based on family and religious values, eschewing all things modern, such as cars and electricity. An otherwise closed community, the Amish open up to the outside world most readily through their crafts and food. They are known for hearty, home-cooked meals, served at communal tables in Amish restaurants, and their most famous dish is their pie – a pie so delicious

that local people often eat it for breakfast. The combination of traditional German recipes and a natural bounty of fruit and nut trees and lush berry patches makes these the finest fruit pies in the world. From juicy apple and ripe peach to sour cherry, tangy rhubarb, plump raisin, sticky pecan, or wild huckleberry, Pennsylvania Dutch pies have the perfect blend of tart and sweet flavors, oozing through a flaky lattice crust or hiding under a crunchy crumb topping.

There are special pies, too, that are rarely found elsewhere. Like the famous schnitz pie – normally made with dried apple slices, this uses green tomatoes in late fall when the apples run low. Or the syrupy, cakelike shoo-fly pie, made with molasses and brown sugar, which comes in thick, gooey "wet-bottom" or thin "dry-bottom" varieties. Its whimsical name came from the need to shoo the flies away as the pies cooled. The popular whoopie pies are not really pies at all, but more like huge cookies, consisting of a sandwich of two small, thin rounds of chocolate cake filled with icing. A Pennsylvania Dutch table is always laden with wonderful home-cooked dishes, but it's the scrumptious desserts that keep everyone coming back for more.

### Amish Markets

One of the delights of visiting Lancaster County is visiting the food markets. Lancaster City's **Central Market** is the oldest farmers' market in the US, and a good place to buy cheeses and fresh-baked desserts. **Columbia Market** sells lots of local produce, and is housed in a historic structure with a dungeon beneath (there are guided tours). In Bird-in-Hand, the **Farmers' Market** has fresh produce and local crafts, while **Kauffman's Fruit Farm and Market** has delicious homemade sweet apple cider, apple dumplings, and deli items. In Ephrata, the **Green Dragon Farmers' Market & Auction** sells baked goods and Amish-made items, and the **Village Farm Market** has a wonderful selection of fresh-baked pies and specialty bakery items. Markets have different opening days and hours, so check locally.

### Three Days in Lancaster County

There's lots to enjoy, apart from the food. You can explore the Amish way of life from old-fashioned horse-and-carriage rides to tours of Amish homesteads. There are historic mansions and museums, and dozens of art galleries. Shop for antiques, hand-stitched quilts, and other crafts, or expertly fashioned Amish furniture.

**DAY ONE** Immerse yourself in the Amish life with a visit to the **Amish Country Homestead** at **Bird-in-Hand**, or the **Landis Valley Village and Farm Museum** in **Lancaster**. Admire antique quilts at the **People's Place Quilt Museum** in **Intercourse**. Take an afternoon **horse-and-buggy ride** through the countryside.

**DAY TWO** Take a foodie tour of Lancaster County. Watch Pennsylvania Dutch cooks making pies and putting up canned jams, preserves, and more at the **Jam and Relish Kitchen** in **Intercourse**. Try your hand at twisting pretzels at the **Intercourse Pretzel Factory** or **Sturgis Pretzel Bakery** in **Lititz**. Nearby, watch candy-makers at the **Wilbur Chocolates Candy Americana Museum**.

**DAY THREE** Follow a scenic driving – or cycling – route and discover some of the region's **covered bridges**. The tourist office has several itineraries.

### Essentials

#### GETTING THERE

There is an **international airport** in Philadelphia; Lancaster has a small airport that connects to BWI (Baltimore Washington International). **Trains** and **buses** run to Lancaster County from Philadelphia. A **rental car** is essential for touring.

#### WHERE TO STAY

**Stone Haus Farm B&B** (inexpensive) is a 200-year-old working farm. [www.stonehausfarmbnb.com](http://www.stonehausfarmbnb.com)  
**After Eight Bed and Breakfast** (moderate) is an antique-filled 1818 colonial home in Paradise, Pennsylvania. [www.aftereightbnb.com](http://www.aftereightbnb.com)  
**The Inn at Twin Linden** (expensive) is an elegant retreat in the heart of Amish country. [www.innatwinlinden.com](http://www.innatwinlinden.com)

#### TOURIST INFORMATION

501 Greenfield Rd.; [www.padutchcountry.com](http://www.padutchcountry.com)

**Above** Horse-drawn travel is a sign of the Amish commitment to tradition and the virtue of living in a simple, unhurried, natural way

